

STUDY SHEET — PARASHAH NITZAVIM/VAYELECH

Deuteronomy 29:10–31:30 · Haftarah: Isaiah 61:10–63:9 (seventh comfort sabbath) · Gospel: John 12:41–50 (confessional, not a peshat-determiner) · The Frame

§0. Observation round

0.1 Blind observation

The text is full of verbs of stepping in, choosing, doing, passing on. You all stand present today to enter into the covenant (29:10-12), also on behalf of the one not yet here (29:14). There is a hidden figure: the root that bears 'gall and wormwood', the person who secretly blesses himself and yet walks his own way (29:17-18). After exile you return and do (30:1-2). The commandment is not too heavy, not far, not in heaven — 'very nigh unto thee, in thy mouth and in thy heart, that thou mayest do it' (30:11-14). 'Choose life' (30:19). And Vayelech: be strong, hand it over to Joshua (31:7); read this Torah aloud every seven years — men, women, children, stranger — that they hear, learn and do (31:11-12); the Torah and the song as witness (31:19,26).

0.2 The four axes as an open question

Where does the weight fall — on what God gives (Source), on what the human answers (Will), on the wholeness between hidden and open (Coherence), or on the movement through time (Trajectory)? I leave that open here and read it off only after the blocks.

0.3 Read-off center of gravity

● The rhetorical mass of the parashah (30:11-20 + all of Vayelech) lies on doing, choosing, handing on — not on receiving. The hinge with last week makes it sharp: Ki Tavo ended on 29:4 ('the LORD hath not given you an heart to perceive'), Nitzavim arrives at 30:14 (the word is already in your heart, to do). The same two verses, side by side, opposite emphasis. That is the turn: from the withheld heart to the acting heart.

0.4 Framing test

● The reflex puts the weight on receiving / defencelessness, and there is one verse that truly carries that reading: 30:6, 'the LORD will circumcise thine heart to love Him.' ● That verse is no subclause — it is the ground. But the parashah does not set it as climax; it sets it as precondition: because the heart is freed and the word is brought near, doing is no longer an autonomous feat but a reachable answer. So the test does not pull 'grace' and 'doing' apart — it grounds the doing in the given nearness. Whoever makes 30:6 the landing place and 30:11-20 a subclause imposes the template; the text turns it around. The tension 30:6 ↔ 30:14 remains an open anomaly, not smoothed over.

§1. The thread

The word is not far away and not in heaven — it is brought near, in your mouth and your heart, to do it; and that done faithfulness is not private but passed on: from us to our children, from Moses to Joshua, from this generation to the next. The grace is that it has been made reachable; the calling is that you step in, choose and pass it on.

§2. Peshat per block

29:10-14

All stand present, from head to water-drawer, to enter into the covenant and its oath; God confirms them as a people — also with the one 'not here today'. ● Key: stepping in (actively entering), and the covenant reaching beyond the present generation.

29:15-28

Warning: the root bearing poison is the person who secretly blesses himself (29:18). Wrath, exile. Then 29:29 (MT 29:28): 'the secret things belong to the LORD; the revealed to us and our children, to do them.' ● Contrast hidden ↔ revealed; the revealed side is explicitly a do-command.

30:1-10

After exile: return (teshuvah), God gathers, God circumcises the heart (30:6). ● Here is the Source pole: the restoration is God's act, and the freed heart precedes the loving.

30:11-14

The commandment is not too wondrous, not far, not in heaven, not over the sea — near, in mouth and heart, 'to do it'. Three times la'asoto (to do it). 🟡 Textual witness: 4QDeut-b/LXX add 'and in your hands' — variant, strengthens the doing-side.

30:15-20

'I have set before you life and good, death and evil... choose life.' 🟢 The choice is laid with the human; heaven and earth as witnesses.

31:1-30 (Vayelech)

Moses (120) hands over to Joshua ('be strong and of good courage', 31:7); the Torah is written and read aloud every seven years to the whole people incl. children and stranger (31:11-12); the foretold falling away; the song and the Torah beside the ark, as witness (31:19,26). 🟢 Handover and transmission as a movement of its own.

§3. The two bearing axes

Will (bearing)

Stepping in (29:11), returning and doing (30:2), the near doing (30:11-14), choosing (30:19), being strong and handing over (31:7), hearing-learning-doing (31:12). Answer within reach, not self-sufficiency: the word is brought to you. Open anomaly: where does 'chosen doing' turn into 'my own strength'? (cf. 8:17)

Coherence (bearing, second pole)

No gap between the hidden heart and the public deed: the root of poison lies in the secret self-blessing (29:18); the revealed side is ours to do (29:29); and the people stand surety as one body — arvut. The song as witness (31:19) guards precisely the coherence between promise and future deed. Open anomaly: the nekudot on 'for us and our children' — tradition set a mark on exactly this passed-on responsibility; why?

Source and Trajectory (supporting)

Source is real (30:3-6) but does not carry the weight here; Trajectory (exile → return, Moses → Joshua, generation → generation) is rising and feeds the 'passing on' side, but serves Will, not as a core of its own.

§4. Deepening — the sources round

Order followed; yield per witness kept brief.

Van de Giessen 🟢 — (1) nekudot / puncta extraordinaria on lanu ulevaneinu (29:29 / MT 29:28); function probably: marking uncertain letters (Qumran usage). (2) 30:14: 4QDeut-b and LXX read a plus, 'and in your hands, to do it'. Both verses close with a setumah. → The textual ground strengthens the action-side even before any interpretation.

Onkelos — not yet verified; open verification point (Sefaria). 🟡

Rashi 🟢 — 30:12: vére it in heaven, it would remain your duty to go up after it and learn (reachability = ground for effort). 29:29: hidden = private conduct (not our responsibility), revealed = indeed ours; the dots qualify that collective duty (binding only after the Jordan) — here kol Yisrael arevim hangs.

Ibn Ezra 🟢 (brake) — 'not in heaven' merely unfolds 'too wondrous' (v.11): not-unreachable, grammatically. Prunes away the over-pious reading.

Ramban 🟢 (coherence) — the near commandment = teshuvah: return is not far, needs no prophet or distant sages, do-able even in exile. Divergence with Rashi (whole Torah vs. return) — both land on human ability.

Midrash / aggadah 🟡 — lo bashamayim hi: the Torah is handed over to the human; even a Voice from heaven is overruled (oven of Achnai). And on the dots: Ezra honestly holds the uncertainty rather than polishing it away.

Did the round shift the center of gravity? Yes. From a Source / receiving landing to Will / Coherence: the near word is near to be done and passed on. Every witness pushes the same way; the reflex (30:6 as climax) is exactly what the sources contradict.

§5. Directional test as horizon

🟡 (confessional, no climax) John 12:47-50 puts Yeshua's last word to the crowd on words that want to be done: 'if any man hear my words, and believe not...' (12:47); 'I have not spoken of myself; the Father gave me a commandment what to say' (12:49-50). The near-word-to-do, embodied — a Mouth that speaks 'not of Itself', precisely the opposite of the secret self-blessing of 29:18. Romans 10:6-8 (Paul cites 30:12-14) is the confessional bridge: the 'word nigh thee' becomes the word of

faith — horizon, woven, nót overriding the peshat (the plain sense stays: the commandment, to do it). ● 12:48 ('the word shall judge') is kept sober as the seriousness of the near word, not as a triumph- or judgment-climax.

§6. Status table

Claim	Status
The near word is near 'to do it' (3× la'asoto, 30:12-14); the choice laid with the human (30:19)	● bearing
Coherence hidden ↔ revealed; arvut; handover as a movement of its own (29:18,29; 31:7-12)	● bearing
30:6 (God circumcises the heart) carries the Source pole — ground, not climax	● bearing
4QDeut-b/LXX 'and in your hands'; nekudot on 'us and our children'	● suggestive / textual variant
Lo bashamayim hi / Achnai: Torah handed over to the human	● illustrative
Reflex-landing on receiving / defencelessness as climax	● watch
The near word embodied in Yeshua (John 12; Rom. 10)	● confession
Onkelos rendering of 30:11-14	● open verification point

§7. Podcast translation

You know the difference between something on the top shelf — you have to fetch a ladder, ask someone, reach for it — and something already in front of you on the countertop. God does not say here: climb to heaven to fetch my word. He says: it lies already in your hand. In your mouth, in your heart, in your hands. Wé did not have to go up for it; it was brought tó us. Bút — mark this — near is not the same as non-committal. What lies in your hand asks to be dóne. And not only you: you lay it in your child's hand, as Moses laid it in Joshua's hand. It is not a burden you carry alone; it is grace that became do-able, and that you pass on.

§8. Source accounting

Van de Giessen, Notes on Deuteronomy (project file, ch. 29-30: nekudot 29:29 / MT 29:28; textual variant 4QDeut-b/LXX at 30:14; setumot).

Rashi on 30:12 and 29:29, Ramban and Ibn Ezra on 30:11-14 — verified via Sefaria.

Aggadah (lo bashamayim hi / oven of Achnai; nekudot tradition) ● via Sefaria.

Onkelos: still to be verified (● open verification point). Name: Yeshua.